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r/AskUK • 1mo ago
Suffering1s0ptional

How to deal with invitation to birthday party asking no gifts?

Serious Replies Only

My son has been invited to a 4th birthday party and the invitation says “please no presents”. I don’t know the family, it’s one of his preschool friends. I’m not British and I’m not sure if this is one of those culture things that are indirect and you don’t mean what you say.. I wonder if I need to bring a small present anyway?

EDIT: Amazing! Thank you all for your replies :)

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AutoModerator MOD • 1mo ago •

Bastayaporfa • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

If they asked for no presents I wouldn't bring a present

954 Reply

LittleSadRufus • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

At my kids first school, the parents made a pact not to bother with presents. It was wonderful.

At her next school, the parents were competitive with their generosity to the point of absurdity. It got very stressful until I realised just a well chosen favourite book went down well and steered clear of anyone trying to compete.

241 Reply

[deleted]

justherebctwittersux • 1mo ago

Bring a card with a nice message!

69 Reply

Drug_Taker917 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

What are you, some kind of mind reader? How do you know they don't want presents?

10 Reply

iBewafa • 1mo ago

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Create

...

But that was the only party that said no gifts. Many more parties seem to flag books though so I guess things are changing.

We haven't done a non family birthday yet but she's always gotten unlucky with secret santa etc where the parent of the other kid hasn't put any ounce of thought into the gift.

10 Reply ...

weeble182 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

Alot of parents have started to ask not for presents because if you invite 30 kids to a big party, you'll get 30 cheap pieces of tat filling up your house.

I know some get around this by gifting a book. Id probably just put a fiver in a card

624 Reply ...

Few_Industry_7760 • 1mo ago

This is the way. I used to get round the present chaos by asking if I could put some money in a card to put towards whatever the birthday child was saving for. Cheaper than buying even cheap tat when you factor in wrapping paper, tags etc

146 Reply ...

Jacktheforkie • 1mo ago

Plus the child gets to pick what they get

46 Reply ...

tiptoe_only • 1mo ago

Book tokens are still a thing too!

21 Reply ...

Few_Industry_7760 • 1mo ago

They are. But books seem to be £7.99 and above in book shops. A fiver is cheaper, and universal.

21 Reply ...

Serious_Escape_5438 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

At our school the parents have all agreed that for large parties instead of a gift everyone gives a small amount of money in advance to buy something really wanted.

17 Reply ...

Homebrew_in_a_Shed • 1mo ago

We did this for my kids. It works out really well. My son got some great Lego

11 Reply ...

HansNiesenBumsedesi • 1mo ago

could you just respect their wishes?

75 Reply ···

Homebrew_in_a_Shed • 1mo ago

We got around this when my kids started school. Someone, a mum, would collect $5 off each party goer. Then birthday boy or girl ended up with a nice present. Worked really well, apart from one parent who didn't like the idea

But OP should respect their wishes and not get a present.

9 Reply ···

Kim_catiko • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

I wish I had done this now. My son's 4th birthday party is next weekend and I am dreading the amount of crap he is going to get.

I usually buy a nice puzzle or a game the child can play with their parents, but I know a lot of people just pick up whatever toy and roll with it.

3 Reply ···

zedexcelle • 1mo ago

Our class has a thing where if you're doing a class party everyone gives an amount like three quid and then the parents decide what to spend it in or put it towards.

1 Reply ···

Haven_Writes • 1mo ago

Cards are the way to go. They can be displayed for a month or two and then binned or put in storage. And you can include a bit of cash (not a lot. A fiver is a good suggestion).

Alternately, maybe a balloon? Kids love balloons and they don't last very long so they don't clutter up the house for very long. If the parents are hosting at home, you could also offer to cook something or bring some snacks, but always run it by them first. Don't just show up with a dish like it's a potluck. Kids might have allergies or be picky.

-10 Reply ···

Ohtherewearethen • 1mo ago

This would be really weird. It's just a class invitation to a party. The parents don't know eachother and they don't want someone they don't know bringing food or offering to cook something. Don't do this, OP, it's really odd.

50 Reply ···

Haven_Writes • 1mo ago

Again, that one is conditional on asking the parents beforehand. Hosting a kid's party at home is a LOT of work, so if you know the parents, you can ask to bring something or ask if they need help setting up or cleaning up. But again, always ask first.

11 Reply ···

More replies

Skip to main content

Create

to bring something especially when it's a party. Is this really considered strange in the UK?

5 Reply ···

More replies

KnowingWoman • 1mo ago

I agree 100% - if the parents have requested no presents, you must respect their wishes and bring nothing to the party except your child.

A cute birthday card would be a nice gesture though.

1 Reply ···

Bexmuz • 1mo ago

If I got an invite to a birthday party and was told no presents, I wouldn't bring a present

Maybe a birthday card?

178 Reply ···

[deleted]

Lassitude1001 • 1mo ago

Just don't bring presents, there's probably a reason because I've never once seen anyone write that in a birthday invite.

124 Reply ···

spaceshipcommander • 1mo ago

As the father to a 7 year old, my house is full of toys. Every Christmas I ask people not to go mad and yet she ends up with so many new toys that she doesn't play with most of them before next Christmas.

The last thing I want is another bag of cheap tat that people feel obliged to bring, on top of what my family already sends.

Not only is it wasteful, I'd rather people spent money on things they need. I don't know everyone's financial circumstances, but I live in quite a cheap area and I wouldn't be surprised if none of the other parents earn more than me. I don't want someone to spend even £10 they don't have on something my daughter will never use.

159 Reply ···

Lassitude1001 • 1mo ago

Perfectly acceptable reasoning tbh. Not far off the same with my 6yo.

16 Reply ···

RonsonGlitter • 1mo ago

I get this from the other side with my nephews. They've already got everything & I suspect they too don't play with everything before next Christmas. I wind up pushing the boat out & getting them something too big. I think just vouchers from now on.

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Thank you so much for the 11 new bead crafting sets to go with the other 28 bead crafting sets which she never wants to play with, and even if she did we wouldn't let her because we have a one year old who puts all the crap she drops on the floor in his mouth faster than the noo noo from teletubbies.

6 Reply ···

CicadaSlight7603 • 1mo ago

Probably about half the whole class parties my children attended had a no presents rule. Later when they start inviting just a few close friends presents become more common again.

It's usually about avoiding mountains of gifts for kids who already have a lot, environmental awareness, and inclusion so no one feels they can't afford to attend.

12 Reply ···

dreadwitch • 1mo ago

My daughter did it for her kids 4th birthday. He has way more toys than they have room for, her house is tiny lol she instead said if people wanted to spend money on him she'd prefer money to put his savings.

5 Reply ···

Responsible_Rub3412 • 1mo ago

That's nice of them. 👏🏻 👏🏻 👏🏻 They just want your kids presence

67 Reply ···

DanielReddit26 • 1mo ago

Maybe OP misread?

"We don't want your presence - please just post us your gifts"

41 Reply ···

Responsible_Rub3412 • 1mo ago

Arr I didn't flip the invitation....my bad. Better luck next year

2 Reply ···

tiorzol • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

Yea I love this. Not sure how the kid is gonna feel about it but it's nice to think about those who are strapped at the mo

4 Reply ···

CicadaSlight7603 • 1mo ago

In our case we always made sure our children were on board first. Not a bad lesson for your children to consider whether their friends coming is more important than getting gifts, with the awareness that some families might struggle or feel embarrassed. This is in a well off area. It was quite common.

He could have everything he needs and just want presence aswel.. I think my son would rather people than presents. $50 (NZ) is average present price where I am with card that defo could make people avoid. Times are hard.

3 Reply ···

WillowCreekWanderer • 1mo ago

Plus for some kids, getting so much stuff at once can be quite overwhelming (especially if there's not much space at home to store it all)

1 Reply ···

tiorzol • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

Twenty quid sounds about right yea.

My son is three so don't know if he'd be this forward thinking yet!

0 Reply ···

More replies

Le_Fancy_Me • 1mo ago

Yeah, if you did want to show you were in the giving spirit but they asked for no gifts. I say if you have the time maybe sit down with your kid and craft a handmade card for the birthday boy/girl. That way you are respecting their wishes of not bringing a present but don't show up empty handed either.

Otherwise if you are on good terms with the respective parents you can always ask if there is anything you can bring that will be helpful or a chore they would appreciate your help with. Like picking up the birthday cake, blowing up balloons, bringing some soda/juice, cups, plates, snacks or helping set things up or assisting with the cleanup.

1 Reply ···

Coconutpieplates • 1mo ago

If it's written in an invite, they mean what they say. So no gifts, means no gifts.

67 Reply ···

El_Moochio • 1mo ago

Yeah if they are British then that's about as direct a request as possible. Likely they agonised over it for a bit before writing it. Would personally not take anything and not mention it when there either.

47 Reply ···

Saint-Snorlax • 1mo ago

Respect their request.

35 Reply ···

TheDisagreeableJuror • 1mo ago

Skip to main content

Create

monkeymidd • 1mo ago

When ever my tiny human got that , I always stuck the £5 I would have spent on tat in a card , was always appreciated.

22 Reply ···

PassionFruitJam • 1mo ago

Ok. I am British but these replies of "oh if they say no gifts don't bring a gift just give them money" are confusing me frankly. Because cash gift is still a gift isn't it? Am I missing something?

17 Reply ···

Loose_Acanthaceae201 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

You aren't, except that it's so ingrained in British children's party culture to arrive with a gift (and leave with a party bag) that people struggle not to.

I have hosted literally dozens of children's parties and I can tell you that being very blunt in invitations is the only way to *reduce* the volume of gifts. Even if you instruct or beg people not to bring gifts, they can't help themselves.

Once we very specifically said he'd be thrilled with Hot Wheels, and he was indeed thrilled with half a dozen little cars in total. Nobody would have spent more than £2, and not all of them were new. It was great.

Another time, a whole class party, and youngest child so a house already bursting at the seams with age-appropriate stuff, we said please no gifts but if you must then a pound in the card. Only one person took me literally, so an eight year old netted A HUNDRED AND FIFTY QUID which took him almost two years to spend.

11 Reply ···

Different_Focus_7461 • 1mo ago

Bring a card and that's it!

14 Reply ···

Equal_Cod_177 • 1mo ago

We did a no gifts party when daughter was about the same age and assumed people wouldn't bring anything. Most people did bring something small such as a voucher or even a lovely little plant (4yr old was thrilled with that one in particular).

12 Reply ···

CicadaSlight7603 • 1mo ago

Pot plants are surprisingly popular with the 4-10 age group!

6 Reply ···

terryjuicelawson • 1mo ago

of honestly pretty cheap token gifts when they already probably have way too many as it is. It won't be appreciated if you still bring one, as ungrateful as that seems (not that they would say anything).

11 Reply ···

originallyale • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

I'd definitely take a birthday card, but if they specifically asked for no gifts then I think it would be awkward and potentially rude to turn up with a gift!

11 Reply ···

Repulsive_State_7399 • 1mo ago

Honestly, we all only have so much room in our houses, relatives want to send presents, kids dont want to part with toys they already have. Another 30 presents isnt a fun thought. Im past the massive party days, but at least half used to go down the charity shop. Its also terribly rude to ask for cash instead, so better to ask for nothing. I would also never want one of my kids friends not to come to a party because they couldn't afford a gift. £5 in a card if you want to. If not, just a card.

10 Reply ···

Expression-Little • 1mo ago

Cards are nice - you can put them up for about a week then recycle them. Up to you if you put money in it.

7 Reply ···

twinkletots1 • 1mo ago

No this isn't like that stereotype of someone saying "great, have fun" when they really mean "fuck you!"

As others have said £5 in a card is spot on

7 Reply ···

Icy-Astronomer-8202 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

Don't bring them presents? They specifically requested this.

7 Reply ···

DeapVally • 1mo ago

Seems pretty straightforward to me 🤷

6 Reply ···

CicadaSlight7603 • 1mo ago

Just take a card unless this kid is best friends with yours.m

We asked for this for whole class parties. Firstly we REALLY did not need or want thirty new toys or pieces of plastic in our house. Our children didn't lack for family gifts and toys.! Secondly in a whole class situ

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Create

6 Reply ···

bedlam_styx • 1mo ago

This!

My son ended up in a private school for a year (a long, dull, poverty-inducing tale) along with a some others in the same situation. Half the class had families who were very... 'comfortable'. The rest of us? Not so much.

We pretty much fell into this idea straight off the bat because we knew at least two families who were even more skint than us trying to get by. No presents. And no stupidly big parties. Most of them ended up being a giant play date and all the kids preferred that anyway. 🤷‍♀️

4 Reply ···

hamstertoybox • 1mo ago

I've just sent out no gift invites, people seem really awkward about turning up empty handed and keep asking if cards and money is okay. Personally, it's fine if they do but I'm not bothered if they don't.

5 Reply ···

Lunaspoona • 1mo ago

Ask if you can make a donation to a charity of their choice in place of a present if you feel you need to give a gift?

5 Reply ···

silly_font • 1mo ago

This is such a good shout.

1 Reply ···

Hirokihiro • 1mo ago

If they said 'no gifts' they were being polite. If it was written down and sent, it's the truth. That tends to be the rule of thumb haha

5 Reply ···

tryinganewpath • 1mo ago

This is the answer!

2 Reply ···

Streathamite • 1mo ago

The only time I received that request I spent what I would've spent on a present on a book token. I knew the parents were big readers so it would go down well.

4 Reply ···

anabsentfriend • 1mo ago

4 Reply ···

silly_font • 1mo ago

My 39yo heart fluttered then. Getting a card with a badge was such a thrill as a kid.

5 Reply ···

maryamrascal • 1mo ago

My kids make handmade birthday cards for their friends and its way better than messing around with presents. All the parents do no presents now and I love it.

4 Reply ···

Le_Fancy_Me • 1mo ago

This would my recommendation as well. A homemade birthday card is going to show some thought was put into attending so you aren't showing up empty handed but you aren't bringing a gift either as requested. On top of that your kid will probably have fun making it and birthday kid will have probably get a kick out of it too. Or worse case scenario kid won't care either way but parents will appreciate the sweet gesture.

If you lack time there are also cards that will let you record a message and play it automatically when opened. Letting your kid record a birthday message can be cute if they aren't able to write yet. And kids usually love stuff that makes noise or lights up.

2 Reply ···

dreadwitch • 1mo ago

If they said no presents why would you think that means actually ignore that and really bring a present?

When someone says no anything, that's what they mean.

3 Reply ···

yee_mon • 1mo ago

British culture is often like that. It is difficult to understand what people mean.

The one thing that I've picked up over the years is that the word "no" is used so rarely that it is really strong, and actually means what it says. It's the other times when people mean no but don't say it that makes it confusing.

8 Reply ···

applecrumble89 • 1mo ago

We asked for no presents for our sons 3rd birthday. He has a lot of toys and doesn't need anything.

Some people will unfortunately ignore this and bring a present anyway. But honestly, if they have put that on the invitation then they don't want presents.

3 Reply ···

Canadayawaworth • 1mo ago

presents, is about to get a load of presents for their birthday from family and the last thing the parents want is even more stuff to try and store.

3 Reply ···

Le_Fancy_Me • 1mo ago

I think for optimal success you can instruct what you do want them to bring.

For example: "no presents please, just a fun birthday card"

Bonus points if you give a vague suggestion like.

"no presents please, but animal-themed birthday cards are appreciated"

Keeping it vague will allow for parents to find something that meets the requirement easily. But knowing there is something they would be appreciated will keep them from getting you a gift due to a fear of showing up empty-handed.

Some other suggestions are asking kids to each just bring a balloon, a party hat, a drawing or a cup to drink from (helps keep track of which drink belongs to who). Each a relatively simple ask and affordable.

My mum used to put on the invitation to bring some Tupperware to take leftover cake home.

It may seem backwards but giving them a small request will keep them from bringing a gift

1 Reply ···

Physical-Industry-21 • 1mo ago

Cheeky fiver in the card 👌

2 Reply ···

Working-Wealth7056 • 1mo ago

My 9 year old got a load of vouchers for his birthday when he had a party and money in cards. He bought himself some new trainers, football boots and electric hand warmers. The £10/15/20 soon adds up

2 Reply ···

ServerLost • 1mo ago

Tenner in a card, give it to the parents out of sight of the kid.

2 Reply ···

Imtryingforheckssake • 1mo ago

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Create

I always loved these simple interactive pop up cards. I'm sure you and your son could make the birthday kid a fun animal or creature one. I think the effort would've appreciated and well received.

2 Reply ···

twisted_luce • 1mo ago

I'll translate: we don't want loads of plastic shit in our house but wouldn't complain about a fiver in a card

2 Reply ···

snaszyy • 1mo ago

I have literally written "no presents please. Just a card" on my son's birthday invites for his party next week. We've not long had Christmas, he doesn't need anymore toys. And as he is probably Autistic he doesn't really get the social norms like other kids his age do so I don't think he'll miss them.

Additionally, and importantly I didn't want a gift to seem like a barrier to a family coming. I would so much prefer them to feel like they can come to the party without the obligation of bringing a gift. I know money is tight, particularly at this time of year.

If they've asked for no presents, they mean it. Just a nice card. Maybe if your kid if into drawing they could draw a nice picture inside it.

2 Reply ···

Ub3r_Bland • 1mo ago

I'd put a fiver in the birthday card.

1 Reply ···

FISunnyDays • 1mo ago

I comply with the parents' wishes and have my kiddo draw a birthday card for their friend.

1 Reply ···

originalwombat • 1mo ago

Tonybham01 • 1mo ago

It means what it says. No presents

1 Reply ···

coldmammal • 1mo ago

I will not bring a present but will ask my kid to write on a card.

1 Reply ···

TemperMe • 1mo ago

My cousin does this with their kids. Granted the grandparents still always show up with presents. Instead they spend a lot more on the actual party and invite all their little friends from school over.

1 Reply ···

Heavy-Locksmith-3767 • 1mo ago

What do they need to do, start saying "Any gifts will incur a disposal fee" or something?

1 Reply ···

Glad_Boysenberry_673 • 1mo ago

If they've said on the invitation no presents then don't take presents. It's good they've let people know ahead of time. Plus it means you don't have to go to the shops and try to figure out what the child may like and the child doesn't also end up with potential multiples of the same present

1 Reply ···

craftcrazyzebra • 1mo ago

Asking for no gifts isn't a code for anything other than not wanting gifts. If you don't feel right attending or sending your child to a party that specifies no gifts. I usually donate money to a charity in their name and choose a charity close to their heart, eg a children based charity.

1 Reply ···

HELJ4 • 1mo ago

I asked for no presents for my son's 2nd party because we have/had way too much stuff already and lots of family who were buying him things. One parent messaged me to ask if we were sure. 100%. Another brought a present anyway and, of course I had to be appreciative but I could tell it made the other parents feel they'd done the wrong thing by not bringing anything, which also made me feel bad.

I'd not take anything. Just return the invitation when it's your turn for a party.

1 Reply ···

mrsadams21 • 1mo ago

you insist on a gift, son is saving up to buy the number blocks 21-30 set"

That way, if people really want to give him something, they know what the money is going towards, and it's a toy he actually wants

1 Reply ···

SuzLouA • 1mo ago

If you really wanted to give something, you could do something like a picture book, a £5 note in a card, a gift card for the Lego shop in a card, or a donation to a charity in birthday child's name - something that's related to kids (NSPCC or local child support equivalent) or something that would make the kid happy (animal charities are a safe bet, or sponsoring an endangered animal for a year). The parents just don't want a load of cheap tat cluttering their home, so something that doesn't do that is fine.

However, as per other comments, if they've said no presents, you really don't have to do anything. They won't be offended.

If it was me, I have a Cricut machine and like to make personalised stickers with it to include in gifts for my kids' friends, so I'd probably just do one of those in a card.

1 Reply ···

Serious_Escape_5438 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

Sometimes my daughter's friends have made her cards themselves and she loves that.

2 Reply ···

LichenTheMood • 1mo ago

You do not bring a gift. Put some cash or a gift card in a card.

If you absolutely cannot turn up empty handed for whatever reason bring some nibbles for the kids.

1 Reply ···

OutdoorApplause • 1mo ago • Edited 1mo ago

Bring a card, especially if your kid picks it out based on their interests or makes it themselves. And if you have a printer maybe print a picture of your kid with their kid if you have one - my kid is obsessed with photos of "my friendssss" and hoards them like a dragon with gold. Or maybe that's just mine 😅 we have a whole coffee table drawer full of photos.

1 Reply ···

Steups13 • 1mo ago

Are they Asian? It's standard to put Jo gifts out of politeness so it doesn't look like you're desperate for a gift, but definitely take a gift.

1 Reply ···

imnotagamergirl • 1mo ago

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Create

1 Reply ···

tunnocksmystery • 1mo ago

We had an invite saying no presents, but if we wanted to do something, we could donate to a children charity, which I thought was lovely.

1 Reply ···

Apprehensive_Bee4022 • 1mo ago

For my 5 year olds last 2 birthday parties we have said 'please no presents', and we did mean it. We asked for a single £1 coin in a card so she could count them and pop them in her money box instead, which she loved. I would not take a present, and just get your son to decorate a card for them instead

1 Reply ···

Auzurabla • 1mo ago

I would check with other parents, personally. I've been invited to "no presents" parties and always brought something, and so did everyone else.

I don't understand the rest of the replies, I was always taught to bring something anyways - and that the "no presents!!!" thing was just a politeness so people didn't feel obligated.

It depends on the friend group, maybe? I'm always torn by no presents, and personally think it's a little bit mean for you to tell people not to get things for your kids. How does your kid feel about it?

1 Reply ···

DOAHJ • 1mo ago

No presents. Make a donation in his name to charity

1 Reply ···

Exact-Character313 • 1mo ago

They're just respecting that people dislike the "expectations" of getting gifts for people they don't know. It's nothing to think too much over. Bring a bottle of wine for the parents as a thanks for the invitation

1 Reply ···

Infamous-Ordinary-39 • 1mo ago

I have a 5yo and shudder at the stack of presents I see at the birthday parties he is invited to. I put a fiver in the card to not introduce more 'stuff' into their house. I will be asking for no presents at his birthday party and will be very careful with what goes into the party bags.

1 Reply ···

Mrteamtacticala • 28d ago

Bring no present, be passively judgemental of people that did bring them. "Ohh, I guess you didn't get the memo eh?"

AttitudeMysterious41 • 28d ago

Have you see the no crap party / kids party pact ? Pretty much exactly this

1 Reply ···

Particular_Log1349 • 27d ago

This is a very standard ask with kids with special medical or behavioral needs. The parent is asking you to help them by not bringing a present. If you did it would be considered very rude but, if there is an additional reason beyond just not wanting to deal with presents, could lead to behavior or safety issues. I always put this on our invites. This year, 3 kids didn't comply. Two were unsafe (food and not behavior age appropriate) and one was a sensory hell. The additional expectation of the giftees also triggered a behavior event. And our child is well enough to be at school, in her age group, with a dedicated and fully trained one to one so she isn't considered extreme needs locally.

Please respect their request, whatever the reason. They will be very thankful. Use it as a learning moment for your kid to read the invite and respect people's boundaries. If you are uncomfortable not bringing anything then please decline the invite

1 Reply ···

oiseauvert989 • 26d ago

Definitely don't bring anything.

Otherwise everyone ends up bringing small presents to everyone's birthday and then everyone has to throw all the presents in the bin because they never really needed them anyway.

If you want to return the favour you can invite that child to your sons birthday.

1 Reply ···

LeftTale3040 • 26d ago

The no gifts rule makes sure that all kids can attend the party. Some families won't be able to afford a gift and would decline so this takes the pressure off.

1 Reply ···

Immediate_Machine_92 • 1mo ago
Top 1% Commenter

I think any of these is acceptable:

1. Bring nothing.
2. Money in a card.
3. Ask if you can contribute something to the cost of the party (if you're on good terms with the host - risky though because if they say "oh yes you can pay for the balloons" and they're like £200 you're kinda stuck...)

0 Reply ···

Little_Strike_4398 • 1mo ago

Create

-3 Reply ···

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